EXECUTIVE ORDER NO. 22-21

ESTABLISHING THE OREGON INTERAGENCY COUNCIL ON HOMELESSNESS

Every resident of Oregon deserves a safe, decent, affordable place to live, but that reality is out of reach for far too many. Despite tireless efforts and significant progress toward ending homelessness over the last 30 years, Oregon's current systems require equity-focused transformation in order to meet the challenges of the next decade and beyond.

Homelessness and housing insecurity are the unintended products of decades of intentional policy choices across many different public systems, rooted in and perpetuated by structural racism at the federal, state, and local levels. These effects also permeate Oregon's small town and rural communities in uniquely challenging ways. While Oregon's homeless service programs often lead the nation in best practices, we still see unjustly disproportionate rates of homelessness among people who identify as Black, Native, and Latino/a/x, as well as in other historically marginalized communities, which is a product of our stark history of racism and its particular impact on people of African and Caribbean, Native, Latino/a/x, Hawaiian, and East Asian descent in Oregon.

We must continue transforming our systems if we are to make tangible change from our state's current trajectory, systematically and sustainably in all Oregon communities. In order to provide accessible, equitable, and sufficient services to regain security and ultimately prevent homelessness, our systems require an upgrade. Intentional, statewide systems transformation can lead us to an Oregon where everyone who wants a safe, decent, and affordable place to live can find one.

PURSUANT TO MY AUTHORITY AS GOVERNOR OF THE STATE OF OREGON, I FIND THAT:

Whereas, most Oregonians experiencing homelessness are not able to access the range of services and supports they need to establish safety and housing security; and

Whereas, experiencing homelessness exposes individuals and families to grave physical and behavioral health risks that often lead to complex health issues and premature death; and

Whereas, homelessness is disproportionately more likely to affect Black and Native Oregonians, at respective rates of three and four times their share of the total state population; and

Whereas, Latino/a/x families make up at least 15% of the total number of families experiencing homelessness in Oregon and an increased percentage of the number of people living in shelter since 2017; and

Whereas, the health and economic impacts of COVID-19 pandemic led to a 49% increase in the number of people listed who were accessing local homeless services from 2020 to 2021; and

Whereas, in Oregon on a single night in January 2021, a total of 18,007 people were counted as experiencing homelessness with 74.5% living without shelter and 4,579 people living in shelter; and

Whereas, the experience of homelessness is exacerbated for and disparately effects veterans, seniors and older adults, and LGBTQIA+ Oregonians due to a myriad of structural and social pressures and failings; and

Whereas, the safety, health, and well-being of an entire community is destabilized when individuals and families have no meaningful choice but to live outside; and

Whereas, state agencies have a duty to lead the state and support communities in providing for the safety and wellness of all of its residents; and

Whereas, disconnected and difficult-to-navigate public service systems and lacking services exacerbate the impact of housing insecurity and homelessness; and

Whereas, evidence-based practices and trauma-informed care for people experiencing homelessness who are navigating multiple public systems can ease burdens and accelerate the process of regaining stable health and housing security; and

Whereas, the State of Oregon honors the sovereignty of Native American Tribes across Oregon and recognizes and seeks to mitigate the history and harmful impacts of state policy on housing security, health, and communal well-being of Native Americans in Oregon; and

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Whereas, the State of Oregon celebrates thriving Black, Latino/a/x, Asian, Pacific Islander, Tribal and communities of color across the state and recognizes and seeks to mitigate the impact and history of state policy, including Black exclusion laws, land donation, restrictive covenants, redlining, and labor discrimination on housing security, health, intergenerational well-being and homelessness among Black, Indigenous and other communities of color in Oregon; and

Whereas, several forums of state administrators, community partners, and representatives produced recommendations for the state to establish an interagency council to align the multiple state agencies that set policy, fund, and manage programs serving and impacting people experiencing homelessness; and

Whereas, it has been recommended by a state task force that in order to decrease rates of racial disparity among people experiencing homelessness, the state should transform its systems to: (1) share decision-making power with people with lived expertise and experience of homelessness, (2) improve data collection to better understand the scope and impact of homelessness and how it varies by geography, (3) increase access through targeted strategies, and (4) adopt continuous quality improvement processes and an orientation that prioritizes learning, experimentation, and iteration in the development of all statues and rules; all of which can be pursued through high-level interagency collaboration within the state government.

NOW, THEREFORE, IT IS HEREBY DIRECTED AND ORDERED:

1. The Oregon Interagency Council on Homelessness ("the Council") is established.

2. The charge of the Council is to improve and align state programs, funding, and policies to drive progress toward preventing and ending homelessness statewide and to transform and improve state support for communities and people experiencing homelessness across the state.

3. The Council shall consist of:
    a. The Governor or their designee;
    b. The Director of the Oregon Housing and Community Services Department (OHCS);

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c. The Director of the Oregon Department of Human Services (ODHS);
d. The Director of the Oregon Health Authority (OHA);
e. The Director of the Oregon Department of Veterans' Affairs (ODVA);
f. The Director of the Oregon Department of Education (ODE);
g. The Director of the Oregon Department of Corrections (DOC);
h. The Director of the Oregon Youth Authority (OYA);
i. The Director of the Oregon Department of Transportation (ODOT); and
j. The Director of the Oregon Department of Administrative Services (DAS).

4. Additional state agencies may be identified as necessary participants by members of the Council, including Oregon's Department of Justice, and will be invited to join the Council as members by the Office of the Governor. In consultation with the Governor, members of the Council may delegate their role on the Council to senior policy advisors or deputies on a time-limited basis, as appropriate.

5. The Council shall designate two members as Co-Chairs.

6. Staffing for the Council shall be led by the Oregon Housing and Community Services Department. In addition, all member agencies and offices will provide necessary support to advance the work of the Council.

7. Council member agencies shall serve as liaisons connecting their pertinent stakeholders to the work of the Council in order to ensure that the Council's priorities, policymaking, and actions are informed by people with lived experience of housing instability, historically marginalized communities, tribal governments and other representatives of Indigenous communities, service providers, local government administrators, and advocates.

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8. Members of the Council shall not receive per diem for their activities as members of the Council, but may be reimbursed for expenses incurred in attending Council business pursuant to ORS 292.495(2), subject to availability of funds.

Done at Salem, Oregon, this 7th day of October, 2022.

Kate Brown
GOVERNOR

ATTEST:

Shemia Fagan
SECRETARY OF STATE